

Written Rules and Unwritten Reality: Legal Ambiguity and Political Passivity in China

Abstract

This paper explores the way the gap between written rules and everyday enforcement produces political passivity in contemporary China. It does not consider political passivity as mere apathy or lack of information. Instead, it suggests that passivity may be a prudent response to a governance environment where laws, administrative rules, platform rules, and even social norms are ambiguous, unevenly enforced, and shaped by formal or informal discretion. The paper draws on existing scholarship, public case evidence and empirical studies to analyze several mechanisms including rule by law, vague public-order offenses, disguised repression and the transition from rightful resistance to tactical adaptation. It also introduces two contemporary variables of dynamic governance: algorithmic governance and economic pressure. As platform algorithms, AI review systems, real-name registration, and social-credit-like systems become incorporated into everyday governance, technical opacity exacerbates legal ambiguity. Slowing economic growth and local fiscal pressure also create a tension between market predictability and political control. The paper concludes that China's rule system is not only about regulating behaviour but also about constructing citizens' sense of what is safe, possible and sayable.

Introduction

I think it is really interesting to think about China and all the rules they have. China has a lot of rules. With all these rules in China people in China are still not sure what they can and cannot say or do in China. What is really important is to understand how these written rules in China affect the way people in China behave politically in China. People say that China is a country, with a lot of rules and that is true China has a lot of rules. The way people live in China is influenced by laws, government rules, safety rules, policies, internet rules what is expected of them at work sayings that are meant to inspire behavior and things that people just know they should or should not do even if they are not written down. The rules in China are very complex. China has a lot of rules that tell people how to behave. You would think that this would make things predictable. When rules are clear, people should know what they can and cannot do, and what they can do to defend their rights.

In real life things are not that simple. In many areas of Chinese society the problem is not that there are not enough rules. The problem is that the rules are not stable and are not applied consistently. You can have a rule that is clearly written down but not clearly applied in practice. There can be a right according to the law. It can be expensive to exercise that right. A public-order rule may sound normal but it can also include things like speech, petitioning, online expression and symbolic protest. A rule on a platform can sound silly. It is actually a tool for managing risk. These gaps are really important. Rules are not just about how people behave; they also shape how people think about authority like the government of China and the rules of China.

They shape the way people think about risk, participation and silence, in China and how the rules of China affect them.

This paper assumes that political passivity in China is partly the result of legal ambiguity, selective enforcement and the disjuncture between what is codified and what is not. Political passivity here does not mean that citizens have no opinions or lack awareness. People learn to be careful about what they do. They try not to argue with others in public. They are careful about what they say regarding politics. They get used to things not being certain when it comes to institutions. When it seems like it will be too hard to participate, people, with this learned behavior of caution, choose to go along with things instead. This learned behavior of caution is something that people develop over time. Citizens don't just say, "What does the law say?" They also ask, "Will this be enforced?" "Who will enforce it?" "Is this politically sensitive?" "Will I be seen?" and "Is it safer to be silent?"

This argument is elaborated on in seven sections. This paper does a few things. First it explains what the rule of law and rule by law mean in China. The rule of law and rule by law in China are defined in this book.

It then looks at ambiguity as a way for the government to control people, not just a mistake in the way laws are written. The paper shows that ambiguity is used as a governance device in China.

The paper also uses real life examples like how laws are enforced differently in different places, what people say on social media and information from court cases to make its point. The rule of law in China is examined using these examples.

For example it talks about the crime of "picking quarrels and provoking trouble" which is a law that is not clearly defined in China. The paper uses the rule of law and rule by law in China to understand this crime.

It also looks at how the government can suppress people and make them too scared to speak out which affects the rule of law in China.

Then it discusses how people in China are changing from fighting against the government to finding ways to work around it which is related to the rule of law and rule by law in China.

Finally the paper talks about two things that will be important in the future: how the government uses algorithms to control people and how economic pressure affects the rule of law and rule by law, in China. These additions are significant because when it comes to political passivity in the future, it will not only be courts and police who are to blame, but also platforms, automated review systems, market uncertainty and the need for the state to reconcile control with predictability.

Authoritarian Legality, Rule of Law and Rule by Law

An instructive beginning is the difference between rule of law and rule by law. Law is supposed to hold the state back in a conventional rule-of-law system. All officials, courts and law-

enforcement agencies and political authorities are subject to public rules, judicial checks and constitutional limitations. Law is not only an instrument of the state but it is an instrument that can limit the state.

Rule by law is not like that. The law is used to manage, control and discipline society, and there is not complete independence from the judicial rule of the state in the exercise of final political power. That does not imply that the law is devoid of significance. To the contrary, legal institutions can be professional, technical, and extensive. Commercial and civil litigations can be dealt with efficiently by courts. Administrative procedures may be explained in detail. Law could be put at the heart of governance. However, the more important role of law is to enable the state to control society, maintain order, and discipline citizens, instead of always curbing the political power (U.S.-China Economic and Security Review Commission, 2023).

The reconstruction of Chinese law after 1978 is an example of this logic. Formal legal institutions needed to be re-established following the disruptions of the Mao era if China wanted to develop its economy and maintain its social stability. The legal institutions contributed to establishing predictable conditions for contracts, property disputes, foreign investment, and common civil litigation. This reconstruction, however, was not intended to create a constitutional structure that would allow an independent judiciary to check the party-state. Instead it created a system of legal modernity and political supremacy (Horsley, n.d.).

This situation results in a dual legal system. The legal process in everyday commercial or civil cases can seem like a routine. However, when it comes to politically sensitive issues, the normal legal safeguards could be undermined. The political dynamics of a contract dispute are different from those of a public-order case on expression. Citizens therefore learn that law is conditional: reliable in some settings, but uncertain in others. It is this conditionality which is a most important part of political passivity. Some people don't feel law as completely lacking or completely oppressive. For them, it's helpful but unreliable. That instability is the lesson for them to learn, how to distinguish between the mundane legal aspect and political risk.

The Ambiguousness of the Law in Governance

Situations of legal ambiguity are usually seen as a liability. Laws ought to be clear, precise and predictable. There are some things that citizens should know about what is and isn't legal. Officials should enforce the rules even-handedly. Stable procedures should be used to interpret legal provisions. Ambiguity can, in practice, be valuable for governance, however, as it allows the State flexibility. Broad or general rules enable the central authorities to retain the final power of interpretation and at the same time enable the local authorities to have some flexibility in the implementation.

Multiple sources of ambiguity in Chinese governance have been identified, such as the giving of broad policy tasks, moral abstraction, information overload, multi-objective policy stacking, and euphemistic reframing. These are examples of ambiguity that are used to avoid determining clear

boundaries or responsibilities, and to maintain broad policy goals. The outcome is a flexible system for administration and one of uncertainty for citizens and grassroots implementers.

An example is multi-objective conflict. Local governments might be expected to keep jobs, draw investments, cut down pollution, keep things stable, control debt and enforce national rules simultaneously. Such objectives may be in conflict. Local officials may enforce rules selectively when environmental enforcement has an impact on local jobs, or when labor-law enforcement increases costs to businesses. This generates so-called split enforcement: enforcement is different from one part of the country to another as local governments encounter different economic incentives and social pressures (Van Rooij, n.d.).

This is important because it's not just by reading the law that citizens learn but by seeing enforcement. When enforcement is different from area to area, time to time, and/or for different groups of citizens or in response to different levels of political sensitivity, citizens come to learn that written rules are not rigid boundaries. These are “non-verbal” cues that need to be read in the context in which they are given. It's a practical question that gradually evolves from “What is legal?” to “What is safe right now?” That's the start of political passivity.

Empirical Support: From Theory to Observable Patterns

One mistake often made in writing about legal ambiguity is that it can be too abstract. If the argument is merely that it is caution arising from vague law, then it is still reasonable, but weak. To make better analysis, evidence is needed that vagueness and selective enforcement impact behavior. Three types of evidence from existing research are thus used in this paper: regulatory variation, data from digital-discourse, and case evidence published.

First, there is split enforcement in environmental regulation, which demonstrates how written mandates can be differently applied to local contexts. Coastal and wealthier, more urbanized regions might enforce environmental laws more effectively, as a result of their residents' desire for cleaner environments and their administrative ability. Less-developed inland areas may, on the other hand, be more reliant on polluting industries for employment and tax revenues, thus limiting their regulatory autonomy (Van Rooij, n.d.). By itself, this does not necessarily indicate political passivity, but it illustrates a general pattern: The same formal rule may lead to different results depending on local incentives.

Second, disguised repression research offers quantitative data to show that framing in the legal context influences public reaction. One study looked at over 13 million Sina Weibo posts about 28 critics who were arrested in a crackdown in 2013. It discovered that explicitly political charges tended to inflame the public, while non-political charges tended to dampen the volume of discussion and to divert focus away from the critics' political ideas to their personal morality or alleged wrongdoing (Stanford Center on China's Economy and Institutions, n.d.). This evidence is important for it demonstrates that repression does not mean punishment alone. It also concerns framing, perception and manipulation of public sympathy.

Third, in the public sphere, picking quarrels and provoking trouble has come to refer to speech, petitioning, online expression, and symbolic protest all of which are within a vague legal category. Whilst single cases do not substitute for a proper database study, they do provide an appreciation of the spectrum of actions which might be encompassed by a concept of public order as a flexible offence. A more robust future iteration of this project could create a dataset from China Judgments Online or other public databases, in which the Article 293 cases could be coded by year, province, type of behavior, length of sentence, and whether online speech or petitioning was involved. In the present paper, it is sufficient to present the empirical studies and the public cases to demonstrate that the legal ambiguity is not hypothetical. It results in observable behavioural effects.

Picking Quarrels, Provoking Trouble: Case Study

One of the clearest cases of legal ambiguity in China is picking quarrels and provoking trouble. It has been stipulated in Article 293 of the PRC Criminal Law and is used to punish acts of disturbing public order. On the surface, this is a typical public order offence. The problem is the vagueness and imprecision of the terms of the offence which rely on phrases such as “serious circumstances”, “bad circumstances”, “public order”, “insult”, “threat” and “disturbance”. These terms allow for a great deal of interpretation by police, prosecutors and courts (China Media Project, n.d.; Pioneer Academic Publishing, n.d.).

That states attempt to control public disorder isn't the issue. All states do. The issue is when something is worded in a vague way, it can broaden the scope of punishable behavior. In fact, the offence has been deployed for common disturbance as well as for expressing oneself, petitioning, posting online, public criticism and symbolic protest. If one legal definition can encompass a large number of behaviors, citizens are forced to make an educated guess as to where the “no” lies.

This extension of this offense into cyberspace is particularly significant. Cyberspace has been interpreted as a public place, and online speech has been regarded as public-order speech (Pioneer Academic Publishing, n.d.). It therefore means that digital expression can create legal risk, not just offline. The line between misinformation control, public-order control, and political expression blurs.

The impact is more psychologically than legally. The citizens need not know all the intricacies of Article 293 to appreciate its impact. They need only to be told that some types of public expression can have repercussions. People may be reluctant to share political opinions, delete content, be indirect, or avoid public civic activity. Ambiguity of legal category turns into internalized “self-censorship.”

This is why it is possible to have passivity in the law without having it punished continually. When the boundary is not well-defined and crossing is costly, cautious people keep far from the

boundary. Not everything does have to be spelled out in the law. Part of its work is its uncertainty.

Chilling Effects and Disguised Repression

A chilling effect occurs when people restrict their own expression and/or actions in fear of potential penalty. It does not need to be directly coerced in every instance. But the threat of repercussions is all that is required to make people wary. Self-censorship is not simply a quality of personal character. It is generated in an environment where people are aware of the risk of speech (Frontiers in Psychology, 2025).

This is reinforced by digital surveillance. Real name registration, platform monitoring, video surveillance, data retention and online traceability all help to foster the impression of a public behaviour that is 'seen'. When enforcement is not ongoing, the threat of recording or review influences behavior. Uncertainty of whether or not a particular post, comment, or action will catch on has an inhibiting force for citizens.

There's an extra layer of disguised repression. Authorities can frame charges against the accused in non-political terms, for example, tax evasion, illegal business activity, extortion, and any other common criminal offence. This alters the public attitude. When a critic suffers for political expression, their allies may perceive it as repression. If the critic is charged with a non-political crime, the focus can be on the critic himself and his moral or guilty nature.

This is important because of the study of 13 million Weibo posts. Political charges were often explicit and these sometimes generated counter-reactions, but non-political charges created a lesser amount of public debate and lessened support for the critics (Stanford Center on China's Economy and Institutions, n.d.). Legal categories thus are not merely punitive, but constitutive of punishment. Identical state action can be interpreted differently.

This instills caution to the ordinary citizens. The threat of engaging in an activity is not only punishment, but punishment that is not necessarily seen by others as political. Someone can be legally targeted, reputationally harmed and socially ostracized simultaneously. In such a context, it is not only safer to be silent, but is also socially rational.

The Technological Black Box and Algorithmic Governance

The next layer of legal uncertainty is not entirely a matter of human discretion. It, too, involves algorithmic discretion. Under the older version of ambiguous governance, citizens were in doubt regarding the meaning of rules for the police, the courts, employers, or local officials. In the digital age, they also have to contend with uncertainty regarding the interpretation of behaviour by platforms, automated review systems, AI moderation tools, risk-scoring systems and recommendation algorithms. This leads to a new kind of ambiguity, that of the technological black box.

The way a platform is run is not a law. It can still control what people see every day. A platform can remove a post, limit what someone can do on their account, change what people see when they search for something, make a topic less visible, or limit who can see something without giving a reason. Sometimes the person using the platform cannot tell if a human made the decision or if it was a computer program, a list of words, a score that says how risky something is or a combination of all these things. This causes confusion about what's legal and what is not and it is also hard to understand how the platform makes its decisions.

The platform is like a box that people cannot see inside. It also means that the government does not have to look at every post. Instead the government puts pressure on the platforms to follow the rules and the platforms have to decide what to do. The platforms are afraid of getting in trouble so they limit anything that might be a problem. This means that the government does not have to make the decisions. The platforms do and they make them based on what they think the government wants.

This is how the government and the platforms work together. The platforms take the government's rules and turn them into automatic filters, rules for reviewing content, limits on what people can do on their accounts, and controls over what people can see. The government sets the limits. Then the person using the platform has to follow them but they do not get a say in what happens. If someone's post is deleted or they cannot upload something or a topic is not allowed or their account is limited they do not get an explanation. This makes it hard for people to understand what is happening and to challenge the decisions. When a computer program makes a decision it seems like a problem but when a court makes a decision it is a legal matter and people can understand it better.

Self-censorship can be exacerbated through algorithmic governance. When there is legal uncertainty, citizens understand that there are issues that may be dangerous to discuss. The risk is real-time and hidden in platform algorithms. Users may experience that some words, pictures, subjects or word combinations result in deletion or less prominent display, but they cannot know what the criteria are. This may lead to their own self-censorship. Instead they talk about things indirectly, avoid using sensitive language, switch to private channels or cease posting altogether.

The social credit system is based on a similar logic. It connects behavior to access to services, mobility, credit, reputation, and institutional opportunity (Journal of Politics, 2022). The impact is that it offers the concept that behaviour can be measured, recorded and connected to consequences, even if it is only implemented partly or in an inconsistent manner. The citizens start to regard everyday activities as data that can be governed. Algorithmic discretion can, therefore, be more effective in generating political passivity than older forms of ambiguity, in which individuals adjusted themselves in anticipation of official action. They also have to self-censor due to systems they cannot see.

The Relationship between Labor Law, Economic Pressure and Selective Predictability

However, as stated in labour law, ambiguity is not restricted to speech or public order offences. In theory, China's labour laws offer formal labour protections, capped working hours, overtime pay and rights to labour contracts (L&E Global, 2024). The problem is that the exercise of these rights can be expensive. It takes proof, time, legal expertise and a willingness of workers to risk retaliation.

This is reflected in the 996 work schedule, which is typically from 9 a.m. to 9 p.m. six days a week. Despite official condemnations of overtime practices, some industries continue to have excessive overtime due to performance pressure, job insecurity, weak enforcement, and fierce competition (Supreme People's Court Monitor, 2021; Reuters, 2025). This shows a simple rule: having a right does not necessarily mean being able to use it.

That is also a problem that varies from the economy. Selective enforcement may be more easily accepted during growth than during downturns, when workers, firms, and local governments might be willing to accept some inconsistencies in favor of opportunity. But in a down economy, uncertainty is more expensive. Local governments are squeezed for money, private companies cut back on jobs, citizens worry about being laid off and foreign investors want “rules and regulations that are predictable.” In such an environment, flexibility — which has always been a strength for the state's ability to meet several objectives — can be a hindrance to growth.

This puts tension within the rule by law structure. Ambiguity is useful for political governance as it allows for discretion. Predictability is good for the economy because markets need stable expectations. Some of the rules governing commercial and economic activity may become more standardized and predictable, in order to retain private capital, attract foreign investment and reduce business uncertainty. Meanwhile, politically-charged regions can remain ambiguous. The result is selective predictability: predictability is greater in areas where market confidence is needed, but less where political control is paramount.

This is an economic factor that clouds the case. Legal uncertainty does not automatically creep out in all directions at the same rate. It can be expanded in spaces related to public safety, freedom of expression and social management, and contracted in spaces where the State requires business confidence. Citizens and firms learn: “There are rule-governed areas, there are sensitive areas, and there are areas where you must be cautious.”

From Rightful Resistance to Tactical Adaptation

Chinese people have not always responded to the state passively. A type of contention was identified by scholars of rural China – ‘rightful resistance’. In this model, citizens appealed to the central state's laws, policies and promises to call out local officials. They did not necessarily

oppose the state. Instead they pressed their case, and wrote to authorities using official terminology to condemn local misbehaviour (O'Brien, n.d.).

The scope for rightful resistance was contingent on political room. The citizens needed to think that a change through law or higher authority might be possible. They had to be convinced that they could strategically use divisions within the state. They also had to be confident that collective action wouldn't be stamped out right away. That is to say, there had to be a certain level of faith in the ability of the formal rules to be leveraged to counter local injustice.

As politics becomes more sensitive, individuals have less room to do things on their own. The risks of working as a group are getting bigger. The way things are classified by the law is becoming more flexible. It is harder to get rid of digital traces. This might cause people who work for society to change the way they do things from being confrontational to being more tactical.

Tactical adaptation might be holding onto whatever space is left without being head-on. Social organisations, lawyers, religious communities and activists can be transparent with local authorities, downsize their organisations, use non-critical language, participate in official programmes or address technical issues instead of structural issues. They do not want to confront the state directly, but just “survive” in it (Harvard Law School Center on the Legal Profession, n.d.).

The change is significant because political passivity is not necessarily total withdrawal. Sometimes it is a strategic rethinking of participation. People might still be concerned with law, rights and social issues but their actions minimize visibility and risk. Thus, ambiguous law becomes part of citizens' action. This does not always mean no participation; participation becomes procedural compliance, indirect communication, and risk management.

Moralized Rules and Practical Cynicism

Moralized rules play a significant role in Chinese society, not only in formal law but also in extralegal rules. In public discourse, order, harmony, responsibility, civilization, honesty, rule abiding behavior and collective interest have been highlighted. Those values are significant; to say they are only “slogans” is an oversimplification. All societies require their own norms. Where the issue arises is when moralized language is used in such a way that it is overly removed from everyday reality.

If there is a disconnect between what is said and what is done repeatedly, cynicism may result. Rules can be formal and focus on fairness and justice. In reality, it will be influenced by relationships, political sensitivity, institutional interests, timing, local discretion or status. Citizens are officially asked to trust procedures. In fact, many people get the message and know the rules: don't meet head-on, don't argue, don't stand out.

This can lead to being suspicious in a very pragmatic manner over time. Citizens can say what the government says in public, and privately disagree about its depiction of reality. They are

taught two systems simultaneously: the formal system (the slogans, rules, and procedures; the “safe” system) and the informal system (the system of risk, relationship, and silence; the “unsafe” system).

Political participation is undermined by practical cynicism, which is the idea that for public participation to occur, it is important to believe that one's voice is going to count. People think that official language is symbolic and that true decisions are made somewhere else, so they are less likely to engage in good faith. They may comply with rules without trust. They can say the right words, but not necessarily mean them. They seem to comply, but inside they may be somewhere else.

Hence the phrase “silence is not consent.” When a society is quiet, it is not an approving society. Silence can be an agreement, it can be fear, it can be tiredness, it can be calculation, or it can be distrust. When people feel like “speaking does not help much and is dangerous,” it is reasonable to be silent.

Discussion: Compliance to Silence

A common feature appears across these cases. In a rule-by-law system, rules are written, and can be very specific, but also are malleable in the presence of political or institutional considerations. Legal vagueness serves the state's interest of orderliness and discretion. The response of the citizens is to develop a habit of caution.

Vagueness in the law can make expression dangerous as in the case of the offence of “picking quarrels and provoking trouble”. Disguised repression and non-political legal charges are ways to defuse public discussion and sympathy. Algorithmic governance illustrates the point that legal ambiguity can get extended into everyday digital life, in opaque technical systems. Labor law demonstrates that when the cost of enforcement is high, written rights can become hard to exercise. When the economy slows down, ambiguity has its bounds, as markets and investors demand predictability. The anatomy of resistance to tactical adaptation is a move from “rightful resistance” to “tactical adaptation” by civic actors in the face of the danger they face when open participation is no longer safe.

These examples all demonstrate that political passivity is not exclusively a cultural trait, or a civic education deficit. It is a learned response to institutional uncertainty. No one is passive because they lack an opinion, rather it is because they realize that opinions come at a price. They are quiet not because they believe in all the rules but because they don't believe in the repercussions of breaking the rules.

Citizens may not ask anymore if it is right; they ask instead if it is safe in a legally gray zone. That shift has a powerful chilling effect. Many written rules for a society may exist without creating a sense of civic confidence if the rule is not applied consistently. A system of detailed legal provisions does not necessarily lead to rule of law. But detailed law and selective

enforcement can create greater caution, as citizens will be required to constantly read between the lines and read the political context around the law.

This is the leap from code to real life. Citizens are taught the official law, but they are taught something more: don't make yourselves conspicuous, don't push the limits, don't assume that your rights are all you need, and don't think that the law is the same as safety. The unwritten lessons may be influential in political behavior more than the written rules themselves.

Limitations and Research Agenda

This paper is the theoretical and empirical foundation for discussing the issue of legal ambiguity and political passivity in China. The logical next step in this would be to make it more systematic by collecting data. The data set, if comprehensive, could include the year of the Article 293 case, province, type of behavior, length of the sentence, whether the incident was online or offline, and whether it was a petitioning, protesting, or expression case. Such a data set would allow us to test if there is an increase in the level of enforcement around certain political moments, and if there is regional variation across provinces.

The second strand of research would be through semi-structured interviews with labor lawyers, NGO workers, former platform moderators, journalists or citizens who have experienced administrative pressure. The interviews might shed light on how decisionmakers in reality handle uncertainty, how they perceive risk, what they say and what they don't say and about which unspoken rules they abide.

There is a third research line that we should focus on algorithmic governance directly. Future research would be to compare the results of statutory requirements to moderation on platforms, to test the keyword censorship patterns, or to understand how platform content moderation with the aid of AI would affect the dynamic between statutory regulations and everyday speech. That would take the discussion out of the legal grey area into the concept of a wider theory of institutional and technological opacity.

Finally, more in-depth research of economic cycles should be conducted. Ambiguity may have practical constraints if economic slowdown raises the demand for rules in business and labor markets which are easier to predict. It is not about the number of rules in China or fewer rules, but about where rules are predictable and where they are politically flexible.

Conclusion

This paper has contended that legal ambiguity can give birth to political passivity in China, as it generates a gap between the written rules and unwritten reality. China should not be understood as simply lawless or disorganized. It's very rule-based, procedural, and detailed. But detailed rules do not create rule of law when enforcement remains discretionary, flexible, and politically dependent.

If the rules are clear when you read them but not clear when you try to follow them, then people start to think of the law as something that might protect them but something that can be used against them. The law says things like "picking quarrels" and "provoking trouble" are crimes. These words can mean a lot of things like speaking your mind, signing a petition or saying something online. When the government uses rules that are not really about politics to punish people who disagree with them, it makes people focus on whether the person is guilty or not instead of talking about the real issues. Rules that are enforced by computers and websites are not only hard to understand, but also confusing for people. When workers have rights but cannot use them because it will cost them too much they realize that having rights does not mean they can actually use them. The government can make some rules clear. When it comes to things that are sensitive like politics the government can still make the rules unclear if it wants to.

People being quiet and not doing anything should not be seen as people not caring about what's happening. Sometimes people are just reacting to things that're not clear. Being quiet can mean people agree with something. It can also mean they are afraid to say anything or they think it will not make a difference or it will cost them too much. People still have the ability to make choices. They start to focus on being careful following the rules, adapting to the situation, and making private decisions.

The main thing to learn from this is that people cannot really participate in politics just because there are rules written down and a lot of regulations. People need institutions that they can trust rules that are enforced in a way that makes sense and a place where they can talk about what's bothering them without always worrying about what might happen to them. If these things are not available then rules can make people follow them but they will not make people trust the government. Rules can make people know what the rules are. They will also make people know what the risks are. That is what happens when people go from following the written rules to understanding the risks, and from following the rules to being quiet.

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